

Figure 3. And quietly flows the Ganga on a hot May afternoon. View from Alamgiri Mosque.

Varanasi came under the sway of the Delhi Sultanate until 1526 and then of the Mughals. Varanasi's experience during these centuries is now a charged and contentious debate. Muslim dynasties, writes Eck, 'were far from monolithic in their policies toward the sacred sites of the Hindus'. 'There were certainly high moments in these centuries, when Kashi recaptured something of its lost glory. There were times of ambitious temple construction [in Varanasi] and stimulating scholarly activity. But for the most part these were hard centuries.'[12] Still, she adds, 'Banaras continued to be an important center of intellectual life and religious thought'.

Varanasi, in fact, became a major site of the Bhakti movement—a grassroots rejection of Brahminical orthodoxy with an alternative idea of religious piety—led by thinkers like Kabir, Ravidas and Tulsidas. It may seem paradoxical but religious sites like Varanasi and Gaya also benefitted